tend to become more ambitious as their capabilities multiply, and they can take advantage of their increased might relative to incumbent powers in order to assert themselves internationally, even though some attempts may not pan out.[20] Some scholars identify a hegemon as a "system maker and a privilege taker" and rising powers as "rule-takers," "rule-makers," or "rule-breakers," reflecting the preferences and varying levels of power needed to create an international order; to write, accept, or break the rules; and to exploit other entities, shifting the costs of those actions to them or inducing them with carrots to cooperate in advancing a political goal.[21] These distinctions underscore that power exists in a competitive realm with Darwinian (albeit not necessarily zero-sum) overtones: to decide which currencies prevail,[22] whether first-mover advantages hold up or are overturned, which countries set the agendas in the "Green Room," and whether a state is more concerned about being acted upon or has multiple opportunities to influence others.

Given the weight of scholarly disapproval of assessing the international power of states by the unsubtle exercise of counting dollars, missiles, or voting power in international organizations, why do it?[23] First, as G. John Ikenberry, Michael Mastanduno, and William Wohlforth point out, it is "axiomatic that there is some positive relationship between a state's relative capability to help or harm others and its ability to get them to do what it wants."[24] Second, this is how foreign policy establishments in actual sovereign states proceed: They continually assess their state's capabilities vis-à-vis those of both rivals and friends and decide on the feasibility of alternative policy options based on calculations of both the capabilities and preferences of their strategic partners.[25] Third, such shifts may be investigated via both forward- and backward-looking indicators. Understanding which states have exercised influence over others requires a forensic analysis of past state behaviors. In contrast, the interstate distribution of capabilities and identification of significant trends or disruptive change may be useful for speculating about what is to come. It is clear that there is some relationship between material capabilities in time T_0 and autonomy, influence, and structural power in time T_1. Consequently, the remainder of this chapter explores recent shifts in the relative material capabilities of sovereign states and highlights some potentially significant trends that may disrupt the current distribution of power and influence.

MEASURING THE SHIFT IN ECONOMIC CAPABILITIES

The rise of the BRICs into the world's top ten global economies and the ranks of leading regional actors marks the first significant power shift since the creation of the Bretton Woods order. The original four largest non-Western powers, despite weaknesses, present a growth story that has exceeded even Goldman Sachs's expectations. The BRICS contributed half of global growth in the decade ending in 2014, and in 2016, China alone accounted for nearly 40 percent of total global growth—more than four times the U.S. contribution and more than 50 percent greater than all the advanced economies combined.[26]

Since the start of the global financial crisis, U.S. intelligence and corporate communities have similarly recognized a momentous diffusion of power in the world arena, focused especially on Asia. The U.S. National Intelligence Council (NIC), for example, observed, "in terms of size, speed, and directional flow, the transfer of global wealth and economic power now under way—roughly from West to East—is without precedent in modern history." By 2030, the diffusion of power is expected to have a significant impact, "largely reversing the historic rise of the west since 1750 and restoring Asia's weight in the global economy and world politics."[27] Similarly, the McKinsey Global Institute (MGI) projects a shift in the "economic center of gravity," erasing most of the regional imbalances ushered in by the Industrial Revolution.[28] By comparison, in the Washington think tank community and in American academia, there has been a reluctance to investigate the implications of the global power shift toward the BRICS, and a willingness instead to find confirmation in early dismissals of the BRICS as a meaningful group, especially after the growth of these economies started to slow and Russia and Brazil went into recession.[29]

Given the geoeconomic importance of the European Union (EU), it is useful to compare its economic performance to the BRICS. Despite the volatility in their respective economic performances, the BRICS' aggregate economic output amounts to a significant portion of the global economy, as shown in Figure 2.1. The five BRICS combined have doubled their contribution to global economic output since 2000, and in 2016, this amount constituted 22 percent, when gross domestic product (GDP) is calculated on the basis of market exchange rates, or about 30 percent in purchasing power parity (PPP)–adjusted global GDP. Figure 2.1 shows that the BRICS share in 2015 surpassed the EU's share of global output.[30] By 2020, the BRICS' share is projected to reach 25 percent of global output, despite the downturns in Russia and Brazil.